

Armada – Game Design Document

Game Overview

Armada is a mobile turn-based naval strategy game for iOS and Android set in a fantasy-epic, painterly-stylized alternate history inspired by the early Age of Sail. Players command a fleet of ships in 3v3 naval battles from a fixed top-down perspective, issuing orders in simultaneous turns (a WEGO system where both sides plan actions that resolve together) ¹. Gameplay emphasizes strategic ship positioning, timing of broadsides, and classic naval tactics adapted from historical Age-of-Sail principles (utilizing wind direction, executing raking fire on enemy vessels, boarding actions, and maintaining formations). The target audience is midcore to hardcore strategy gamers who appreciate deep tactics and fleet management. The tone is **epic and immersive**, evoking high-stakes naval warfare with grounded worldbuilding and light fantasy twists – imagine the drama of master-and-commander style sea battles enhanced by subtle mythical elements (e.g. legendary captains, mystical weather events) that enrich but do not overpower the historical feel.

Game Pillars

- **Strategic Fleet-Based Combat:** The core of Armada is commanding multiple ships as a cohesive fleet. Players must **plan maneuvers for 3 ships** each turn, coordinate positioning, and anticipate enemy moves. Success comes from outmaneuvering opponents and executing synchronized attacks rather than individual twitch reflexes. Every match is a **tactical chess match on water**, rewarding clever fleet formations and focus fire strategies.
- **Naval Tactics from the Age of Sail:** Authentic sailing-era tactics inform all combat mechanics. Wind direction and momentum affect movement – holding the **weather gage** (upwind position) grants a tactical advantage in maneuvering ². Ships primarily fire broadsides, meaning they deal massive damage from their flanks but are vulnerable at the bow and stern ³. A well-timed **raking fire** (firing down the length of an enemy ship from ahead or astern) can devastate the enemy ³. Classic maneuvers like “crossing the T”, maintaining a line of battle, or executing boarding actions are translated into gameplay rules. This pillar grounds the game in historical realism – **mastery of age-old naval principles** is key to victory, giving the battles a deeply strategic, almost simulation-like feel within a fast-paced turn-based format.
- **Captain Collection & Progression (with Linked Crew Chain System):** Players recruit a roster of unique **Captain characters** to lead their ships. Each Captain comes with distinct abilities and boosts (for example, one might improve cannon accuracy, another may inspire crew for boarding). Captains level up and improve over time, unlocking new skills. Progression uses a character-collection model – e.g. collecting **Captain shards** to promote them and raise their level cap ⁴. In addition, a “**crew chain**” system links Captains with their crew or other captains for bonus effects. For instance, assigning crew members of the same heritage or role to a Captain’s ship could grant synergy bonuses to that Captain’s special maneuver ⁵. Completing a Captain’s **crew chain** (collecting specific officer crew cards tied to that Captain) might unlock an ultimate ability or stat boost,

encouraging players to collect and build themed crew sets. This pillar provides **RPG-like progression and collection**, fostering attachment to favorite captains and their legendary crews.

- **Ship-Based Progression (Primary System):** The primary axis of player power progression is through **upgrading ships**. Each warship in the fleet can be improved via experience and materials earned. Ships have **upgradeable components** (hull integrity, sails for speed and maneuverability, cannons for firepower, etc.) and can be leveled up or ascended to higher tiers. Unlocking higher-tier ships is a major goal: players start with smaller vessels (e.g. brigs or sloops) and gradually command larger ships-of-the-line or war galleons. This tiered progression mirrors the tech trees of historical naval games – moving from lower-tier to higher-tier ships up to the apex of each class ⁶. **Ship classes** (e.g. light frigates, heavy frigates, battleships, etc.) each have strengths and weaknesses, and progression might involve branching choices (for example, upgrading a ship for speed vs. armor). By investing in ships, players improve their fleet’s capabilities, making ship upgrades the primary means to tackle tougher content. This ensures a satisfying sense of growth as cannon decks are expanded and masts strengthened over time.
- **Cosmetic-First Monetization (Starting with Sails):** Armada’s monetization is designed to be **player-friendly and cosmetic-focused**, avoiding pay-to-win. Revenue comes primarily from selling cosmetic items that allow players to personalize their fleet’s appearance – **custom sail designs** being the flagship offering initially. New sail patterns, colors, emblems, and ship liveries can be purchased, giving ships a unique look **without conferring gameplay advantages**. Cosmetic monetization means items have no direct impact on mechanics, maintaining fair play ⁷. Over time, cosmetics can extend to hull figureheads, crew costumes, harbor decorations, ship trails, and more, ensuring a robust catalog of visual flair. The monetization model may also include a **Battle Pass or seasonal cosmetic bundles**, offering exclusive skins or sails during events. All progression-critical items (ships, captains, upgrades) are earned via gameplay, while spending money accelerates style and expression. This pillar aligns with a **fair F2P philosophy**: players can support the game by customizing their experience, and whales can chase prestige cosmetics (e.g. a rare golden sail set) that show off dedication without breaking game balance.
- **Mission-Based PvE Progression with Boss Raids:** The game features a **deep narrative campaign** divided into missions and chapters. Players advance through a series of handcrafted **PvE missions** – ranging from skirmishes against pirate fleets, escort missions, to large-scale fleet battles – that progressively introduce new challenges and story arcs. Each mission has objectives (e.g. “Defeat all enemy ships”, “Protect the merchant vessel for 10 turns”) and rewards resources and loot on completion. At key milestones, players face **boss encounters**: epic battles against formidable opponents such as a giant man-of-war flagship, a fort guarding a strait, or even a fantasy-tinged threat like a sea monster or ghost ship. These boss raids require strategic mastery of mechanics; for example, a boss might have weak points to target or special attack patterns to anticipate. **Boss raids** can appear at the end of a campaign chapter or as repeatable PvE events, providing group challenges (e.g. multiple players each attack a dread pirate king’s fleet and collectively whittle it down). The mission-based structure gives a **sense of progression and accomplishment** in PvE, as players push forward in the campaign story and face increasingly epic showdowns.
- **Time-Limited Co-op Raid Events (Social PvE):** Beyond the core campaign, Armada will host special **cooperative raid events** at regular intervals. These time-limited events invite players to team up (synchronously or asynchronously) to tackle massive shared challenges. For example, a weekly or

monthly event might introduce a **Grand Armada Raid** where the community or guilds must band together to defeat an overwhelmingly powerful enemy fleet or a monstrous leviathan from the deep. Players can join forces in groups (e.g. up to 3-5 players) to **co-operatively battle** the raid boss, each bringing their best fleet to the fight. The raid's difficulty scales to require multiple attempts or contributions – no single player can take it down alone. Rewards are distributed based on participation and damage dealt, with bonus loot if the community achieves certain milestones (e.g. if the boss is defeated within the event window). These co-op raids encourage **social interaction and teamwork**, often facilitated through guilds (fleets) or friend lists. They also provide exciting **limited-time content** that refreshes the endgame meta – new raid bosses might have unique mechanics that push players to theory-craft new strategies or fleet compositions. Coordinating with others to conquer these events fosters a strong community and adds a **social PvE dimension** beyond the solo campaign.

- **Asynchronous PvP with Fleet Loadouts:** Armada offers competitive play through **asynchronous PvP battles**. Players can form a **defense fleet loadout** (choosing 3 ships, their captains, and positioning) to serve as their defending fleet when other players challenge them. In asynchronous PvP, battles are not real-time head-to-head but rather occur **on-demand**: one player's fleet (controlled by AI using the preset defensive orders or behaviors) is pitted against another player's attacking fleet. This approach ensures that PvP can happen at any time, regardless of players being online simultaneously, and avoids connectivity issues. It's similar to other mobile strategy titles where attackers face player-built defenses at their own pace ⁸. Players will compete in **ranked ladders or leagues** based on their success in PvP sorties, earning rewards for climbing rankings. PvP focuses on fleet composition strategy – selecting the right ships and captains to counter popular enemy setups – and clever execution of tactics in the battle itself. Because battles are asynchronous, players can study replays of their defense being attacked, enabling them to refine their fleet loadout and AI behavior scripts. The design goal is a **fair, bite-sized competitive experience** that captures the tension of naval engagements without requiring both players to be live. Matchmaking ensures fights between fleets of similar power. Seasonal tournaments or rotating PvP formats (e.g. special rules like "only frigates allowed") can keep the mode fresh. This pillar delivers **meaningful PvP competition** while respecting the mobile platform constraints.

- **Monthly Live Ops & Content Cadence:** Armada is planned as a live service game with a **steady content cadence** to engage players long-term. The development team will release **monthly updates or events**, aligning with industry best practices where top games offer at least one new live event per month ⁹. Live Ops includes a calendar of rotating events, daily/weekly challenges, and new content drops. For example, each month might introduce a new limited-time event (such as a themed PvE encounter or mini-story arc), **new captains or ships** to collect, and fresh cosmetic items (like a seasonal sail design). Major updates could coincide with narrative expansions (e.g. a new chapter in the campaign every few months) or gameplay features (such as a new PvP mode or a guild war system). **Live operations** will also involve community engagement: seasonal events (e.g. a winter festival with bonus missions), holiday-themed raids, and competitive seasons in PvP with reset and reward cycles. The key is to make the game feel like a living world – each month players can expect something new, whether it's a challenging event, a balance update, or a special promotion. Regular content drops and responsive balance tweaks (based on analytics and player feedback) will keep Armada **fresh and evolving**, enhancing both engagement and monetization over time. A dedicated Live Ops roadmap ensures the game remains lively, with the team planning content several months ahead to maintain a consistent rhythm of excitement.

- **Deep Narrative Campaign with Structured Arcs:** Armada features a rich story-driven campaign that unfolds across multiple **structured narrative arcs**. The game's lore is an alternate-history Age of Sail world, complete with rival kingdoms, enigmatic seafaring cultures, and a touch of magic beneath the surface. The campaign is divided into arcs (chapters), each with its own rising action and climax, akin to seasons of a TV series. For example, **Arc 1** might introduce the protagonist captain and their ragtag fleet defending their homeland from raiders, culminating in a boss battle against a notorious pirate admiral. **Arc 2** could escalate to a wider war between empires on the high seas, perhaps revealing a mystical element (like an ancient sea leviathan awakened by the conflict) as the end-arc boss. Each arc has its own thematic focus and characters, while contributing to an overarching epic plot (e.g. uncovering the secrets of a lost civilization that grants immense naval power). Between missions, story cutscenes and dialogue develop the characters (captains have personalities and backstories) and the world's politics and myths. Player choice might occasionally influence minor narrative outcomes (though the main arc is largely linear to deliver a tight story). By structuring the narrative in clear arcs, players can follow a coherent storyline with satisfying conclusions before the next arc introduces a new twist or threat. The tone remains **grounded and serious**, highlighting the peril and heroism of naval warfare, but the "light fantasy twist" allows for surprising story elements – such as a cursed ghost ship fleet or a mythical artifact that grants control over the winds – to elevate the drama. This deep narrative engagement gives context and emotional weight to the gameplay, motivating players to progress not just for rewards but to see the next chapter unfold.
- **Harbor/Base Hub for Upgrades & Social Interactions:** The Harbor is the player's **central base of operations** – a living hub where they manage resources, upgrade ships, and interact socially. Visually, the Harbor is a bustling port town (which serves as the game's primary menu interface in an immersive way). Within the Harbor, players access various buildings to perform actions:
 - **Shipyard:** where ships are built, upgraded, and customized. Players can view each ship in their fleet docked here and initiate upgrades or cosmetic changes.
 - **Admiralty (Command Center):** a headquarters for managing your fleet and captains. Here players assign captains to ships, view their collection, and handle captain training or crew assignments (the crew chain management interface lives here).
 - **Tavern:** a social hub where players can meet NPCs and other players' avatars. It's the gateway to social features like guilds (fleets of players), chat channels, and co-op matchmaking. In fiction, it's where captains gather – in mechanics, it could host a **guild hall** for alliance chat and a friend list to visit others' harbors or share resources.
 - **Market:** the in-game shop for trading resources and purchasing items. Players can spend currency to get upgrade materials, or browse the **cosmetic store** (sails, skins) here.
 - **Dockyard Missions Board:** a board that presents daily quests, events, and missions available, anchoring the Live Ops interface.
 - **Harbor Defenses:** since PvP involves attacking others' bases, the harbor might have defenses or stationed fleets. Players can configure defensive emplacements or garrison ships to protect resources from raids (if such a feature is included).

The Harbor is also **upgradeable** – as players progress, their base can level up or expand, unlocking new features (e.g. a bigger shipyard to hold more ships, or an academy to research global upgrades). This provides a light base-building meta layered atop the naval combat. The harbor serves as a **social stage** as well: players might see representations of allied players' ships visiting, or be able to show off their customized flagship at dock. The atmosphere of the harbor is vibrant and alive, with ambient animations

(sailors loading cargo, gulls flying, waves) to reinforce immersion. By making the hub a tangible location, Armada gives players a **sense of ownership and place** in the world, beyond just menus. It also anchors the **social experience** – through guilds and chat – in a thematic setting, turning a potentially solitary strategy game into a community-driven experience when desired.

Full Feature Map

To summarize, the following table provides a **feature map** of Armada’s major components:

Feature Category	Description
Core Combat	3v3 naval battles with simultaneous turn execution (WEGO system) ¹ . Top-down tactical view with grid/waypoint movement. Emphasis on broadside attacks , firing arcs, and maneuvering for positional advantage. Wind mechanics affect ship speed/turning, and special tactics like raking fire and boarding actions add depth.
Fleet Management	Command a fleet of 3 ships in battle, chosen from your roster. Pre-battle, set formations and initial orders. Different ship classes (frigates, galleons, etc.) for combined-arms strategy. Fleet loadouts saved for quick swapping (e.g. an aggressive fleet vs. a defensive fleet).
Ships & Progression	Ship collection and upgrading is the primary progression. Acquire new ships (via campaign rewards or crafting). Upgrade ships’ components: hull (HP), cannons (damage), sails (speed), crew quarters (boarding strength), etc. Tier up ships to unlock advanced vessels – progression mirrors a tech tree from small sloops to powerful ships-of-the-line ⁶ . Ships have rarity or class categories and can be customized aesthetically.
Captains & Crew	Captains are collectible heroes who command ships. Each has unique skills and stat bonuses. Level up captains (via XP and shards ⁴), promote them to unlock skills. Crew Chain system : assign specific crew officers to a captain/ship for synergy bonuses (e.g. matching faction or role grants buffs) ⁵ . Complete a full crew set for extra powers. Captains have rarity (Common/Rare/Epic) and possibly elemental affinities or factions that affect synergy.
Narrative Campaign	A story-driven PvE campaign with multiple chapters/arcs. Complete sequential missions that increase in difficulty and narrative stakes. Mission types include ship battles, sieges, escort missions, boss fights, etc. Story unfolds via cutscenes and dialogue between characters, with the player’s chosen captains often part of the narrative. Boss raids punctuate arcs as major challenges requiring skillful play.
PvE Missions & Raids	In addition to campaign missions, repeatable missions and raid events are available. Daily PvE skirmishes for resource farming, weekly rotating missions with special conditions, and world boss raids where co-op play is encouraged. Limited-time PvE events keep content fresh (e.g. a high-level raid against the “Kraken of the North Sea” open for one week). Rewards include upgrade materials, new captain unlocks, and cosmetics.

Feature Category	Description
Co-op & Guild Features	Guilds (Fleets): players can form or join fleets (guilds) for social play. Guild features include chat, guild co-op missions , and possibly guild vs. environment challenges (e.g. guild takes down a fortress together). Co-op raids allow friends or guildmates to team up in real time (or take sequential turns asynchronously) against tough AI enemies. Coordination and strategy in team play yield greater rewards.
PvP Battles	Asynchronous PvP arena where players fight others' fleets controlled by AI ⁸ . Set your defense fleet formation in your Harbor; attack other players to climb ranks. PvP modes might include ranked seasons, casual skirmishes, and a ladder or league system. Victory yields PvP currency and seasonal rewards (titles, cosmetic banners). Fair matchmaking ensures balanced battles; higher leagues unlock as your fleet grows. Possibly special PvP formats like tournaments or draft modes for variety.
Harbor/Base Hub	The Harbor is the persistent base. It contains upgrade buildings (Shipyard, Tavern, Market, etc.) and serves as the menu hub. Players upgrade the harbor over time to improve resource generation or unlock features (e.g. Research Academy to boost ship stats globally). The harbor is also where social interactions occur – visiting friends' harbors, seeing guildmates' ships, and global chat appearing as speech bubbles at the Tavern. This hub ties all game systems together diegetically.
Economy & Resources	A robust economy with multiple resources: e.g. Gold (common currency for basic upgrades), Timber and Iron (materials for ship improvements), Crew Tokens (for recruiting/upgrading crew), and a premium currency (gems or "Doubloons") for speeding up progress or buying cosmetics. Players earn resources via missions, daily rewards, and events. Resource sinks include ship upgrades, captain training costs, harbor building construction, etc. Balanced economy pacing ensures progression feels rewarding without excessive pay gating.
Monetization	Free-to-Play with cosmetic-focused monetization. In-app purchases offer cosmetic bundles (unique sails, ship skins, captain outfits) and convenience items. A Premium Pass (Season Pass) may be offered monthly, granting extra rewards (mostly cosmetic or minor resource boosts) for active players. Direct purchase of power is minimized – no overpowered exclusive ships or captains are sold. Instead, monetization leans on player vanity and expression , ensuring a fair experience for payers and non-payers alike ⁷ . Ads are minimal or opt-in only (if at all) in this premium strategy experience.
Live Ops & Events	Continuous Live Operations with new content releases. Expect a monthly event cadence ⁹ – e.g. a new co-op raid, a holiday event, or a limited-time PvP mode. Regular updates add captains and ships (expanding the roster), new story chapters, and quality-of-life improvements. Daily login rewards and rotating challenges keep players engaged between major events. The game supports push notifications to draw players into time-sensitive activities (like a raid boss appearing). A dedicated Live Ops team analyzes player data to tune events and keep engagement high.

This feature map provides an overview of all key aspects of Armada, ensuring that each element from combat to social play is accounted for in the design.

Gameplay Systems

Combat System

Armada's combat is a **turn-based tactical system** with simultaneous order resolution. At the start of each turn, both players (or player and AI opponent) secretly issue commands to their ships – such as movement waypoints, targeting orders for broadsides, or activation of a captain's special ability. Once orders are locked in, the turn executes and both sides' ships carry out their actions concurrently, **simulating the chaos of real naval engagements** while retaining turn-based fairness ¹. Turn outcomes depend on timing and positioning; for example, if two ships attempt to broadside each other, the one that maneuvered into a better firing angle or timed its volley correctly will hit more effectively.

Key aspects of the combat system include **movement, firing arcs, and range**. Ships move a certain distance per turn based on their speed stat and wind conditions – a ship sailing with the wind gets a speed boost, whereas one tacking against the wind is slower. Movement orders can be waypoints on the grid/ocean map, allowing for complex maneuvers like flanking or maintaining distance. **Firing arcs** are primarily to the port and starboard (sides) of each ship, reflecting broadside gun decks. A UI overlay shows each ship's firing cone; enemies within that arc and range can be hit when the ship fires. Reload times (perhaps measured in turns) prevent continuous firing – timing a broadside to unleash right when an enemy comes into arc is a vital skill. Ships also have minimal armament in forward/aft directions (e.g. bow or stern chasers), but these are weak compared to broadsides ¹⁰. Thus, optimal damage is dealt by crossing the enemy's path to deliver full broadsides while avoiding exposing your vulnerable bow or stern.

Damage model: When cannon fire lands, damage is dealt to hull integrity, and there's a chance to damage subsystems (like disabling a mast to slow a ship, or hitting the rudder to impede turning). A critical hit system might allow for chance-based events like an ammunition deck explosion for massive damage if a ship is hit from the side at close range. Additionally, the concept of **raking fire** is modeled – if you manage to shoot an enemy ship from directly ahead or astern (down the length of the vessel), damage is increased (e.g. 150% normal damage) to simulate the shot traveling through the entire ship ³. This encourages maneuvers to "cross the T" of an opponent. Meanwhile, **boarding actions** can occur when ships end a turn in close contact. If a ship specializes in boarding (with high crew strength), it can grapple an enemy to initiate a boarding attack phase, resulting in a damage-over-time or a quick resolution where one crew overcomes the other (potentially even capturing the enemy ship if a special mission or ability allows). Boarding outcomes depend on crew stats and any captain abilities that boost hand-to-hand combat.

Throughout combat, **Captain Abilities** add an extra layer. Each captain on a ship can have an active skill (usable once every X turns) and a passive buff. For instance, a captain might have an active ability "Chain Shot Volley" that, when activated, fires specialized shot to slow an enemy ship's movement next turn. Another might have a passive ability increasing the ship's accuracy or reducing incoming damage slightly. Using captain abilities at the right moment – such as a speed boost to outmaneuver an opponent or a defensive brace for impact before receiving a broadside – often turns the tide of battle. These abilities charge or cooldown over turns, adding a **resource management** aspect to timing their use.

The UI during combat presents an isometric or top-down ocean battlefield with ship sprites/models, a compass indicating wind direction, and UI highlights for current selected ship and its options. Controls are touch-friendly: tap a ship to select, then tap a destination to move (with a path preview factoring wind), and tap an enemy to target for attack. At the end of a turn's planning, a **preview** could show approximate

outcomes (e.g. "Ship A will likely hit Ship B with a broadside for ~X damage if it stays on course"). Once executed, players watch the action play out in short cinematic fashion – cannon smoke puffs, splashes when shots miss, health bars dropping, etc. This offers satisfying feedback for their tactical decisions.

Overall, Armada's combat system marries the methodical planning of turn-based strategy with the **immersive themes of naval warfare**, making every encounter a thoughtful duel of wits. Historical authenticity (wind, broadsides, formations) is leveraged to create engaging mechanics, so players feel like real admirals orchestrating complex battles. The combination of simultaneous turns and naval physics ensures no two battles play out exactly the same, as the interplay of maneuvers and countermaneuvers creates emergent tactical situations.

Fleet & Ship Mechanics

Outside of individual battles, players must manage their **fleet composition and each ship's development**. Initially, players will have a limited number of ships (perhaps a starting frigate and a sloop). Through progression, they can acquire new ships either by **building them in the Harbor's Shipyard** (using resources) or as rewards from story missions ("earned a heavy frigate after defeating that boss") or special events. The game may include a **ship roster cap** that grows with Harbor upgrades, ensuring players gradually expand their fleet. Each ship has a defined class and tier. Example classes might be: - **Brig/Sloop (Light class)**: Small, fast ships with light armament. Useful for scouting, flanking, or chasing down fleeing enemies. Fragile if caught in a broadside duel. - **Frigate (Medium class)**: Versatile warships balancing speed and firepower. The workhorses of the fleet, frigates can engage in line combat or support larger ships. - **Ship-of-the-Line (Heavy class)**: Large, powerful battleships carrying many cannons. Devastating broadsides and durable hulls, but slower and less maneuverable. Key for head-on confrontations and forming the main battle line. - **Special Vessels**: This could include support ships or fantasy variants (e.g. a **Fire Ship** that can be sent to ram and explode, or an **Arcane Galleon** with a magical ability). These add spice to fleet composition with unique roles.

Each ship has base stats (hull points, cannon damage, crew size, speed, turning rate) which can be improved. **Ship upgrades** are handled via the Shipyard interface. For instance, to upgrade cannons to level 2, the player spends Iron and Gold; to improve sails (speed), spend Timber and Cloth; to reinforce the hull, spend more Iron, etc. There might be an upgrade tech tree per ship, or simply linear upgrades per component. Reaching certain upgrade thresholds might change the ship's **tier** (like when all components hit level 5, the ship is considered Tier II, perhaps gaining a slight boost or unlocking a slot for an extra passive buff). Eventually, a fully upgraded ship could be "**refit**" into a new model or variant – akin to evolving it. For example, a Tier III Frigate could be refit into a "Heavy Frigate" model that has an extra cannon deck. This provides a sense of transformation and keeps long-term progression rewarding.

Fleet composition matters when heading into missions or PvP. Players choose which 3 ships (and their assigned captains) will participate in the next battle. There's strategic depth in synergies: perhaps one ship is outfitted with long-range cannons and a slowing shot (good for kiting), while another is a brawler with short-range carronades and strong hull for close combat. The third might be a support ship with an ability to repair allies or lay smoke (for evasion). **Pre-battle formation** settings allow players to position their 3 ships at the start (e.g. heavy ship in center, flanked by lighter ones, or vice versa). During battle, coordinating the ships is key – one can attempt to **cross the T** of the enemy while another herds them into a crossfire.

The game could incorporate a **formation and command system**: players might have preset formation patterns (line abreast, line ahead, wedge, etc.) that impart minor buffs or focus fire behavior. For example, ordering a “line ahead” formation might make your ships follow each other, concentrating fire on the lead enemy but risking raking hits if flanked. A “broad line” spreads them out to avoid area damage but could be defeated in detail. This system would further accentuate naval tactics historically used.

Because players maintain a fleet roster beyond the active 3, there is an element of **fleet building meta-game** similar to character collection games. Some ships might have bonuses in certain modes (e.g. a fast cutter gives bonus loot when used in scouting missions). Players will want to collect a variety of ships and upgrade them to face different challenges. Over time, **powerful legendary ships** could be introduced (perhaps via special blueprints from events) – like capturing an enemy flagship in a narrative mission gives you that unique vessel for your fleet.

In summary, the Fleet & Ship mechanics ensure players are not just fighting battles, but also thoughtfully **assembling and improving their navy**. It taps into the joy of collection and optimization: choosing the right tool (ship) for the job and making sure that tool is sharpened (upgraded) and well-led (with a good Captain). The progression is paced so that even as new ships are added, older ships can remain relevant through upgrades or by assigning them to automated missions/garrison duty, etc., so nothing feels wasted. This layer provides the **strategic long-term planning** aspect to complement moment-to-moment tactics.

Captains & Crew Progression

Captains are a critical component of Armada’s gameplay, effectively serving as the **personification of player progress and strategy**. Each ship in battle is led by a Captain (from the player’s collection of acquired captains). Captains bring two primary things: a **unique ability kit** (passive bonuses and active skills that enhance the ship or affect battles) and **RPG-style progression** (they level up and improve stats such as Leadership, Gunnery, Navigation which could translate to in-game bonuses like extra accuracy or faster cooldowns).

Captain Collection: Players can recruit new Captains through various means – progressing in the campaign might unlock story characters, while other captains are acquired via an in-game tavern recruitment (which could be a gacha-like system or a token exchange). Captains come in different **rarities** (Common, Rare, Epic, Legendary), reflecting their power and scarcity. Higher rarity captains have stronger abilities or more room for growth, but even common captains can be useful with the right synergy. Each captain has a **faction or background** (e.g. Royal Navy officer, Pirate Lord, Mystic Corsair, etc.), and perhaps a class (like “Tactician”, “Brawler”, “Support”) which hint at their playstyle and can tie into the crew synergy system.

Leveling and Promotion: Captains gain experience from battles (or via training items) to increase their level, improving their base stats (e.g. +HP to ship, +damage, etc.). However, they might have a level cap that can only be lifted by **Promotion** – which is done by collecting the captain’s specific **shards or medals** and spending them to rank up the captain (a common system in hero-collecting games) ⁴. For example, a Rare Captain might start at Rank 1 cap level 20; to break to Rank 2 (cap 30), you need 20 Captain shards of that character. Promotion might also unlock new skills or enhance the existing special ability. This gating ensures a progression path and gives value to obtaining duplicate captain shards.

Skills and Abilities: Every Captain typically has one **Captain’s Maneuver (ultimate ability)** and one or more passive **Officer Abilities**. The Captain’s Maneuver is only active when that character is the captain on

a ship (some games call this a captain's ability) ¹¹, and often gets improved by synergy bonuses. For instance, a legendary captain's maneuver might be "Full Broadside: instantly reload and fire all cannons at 110% damage, with increased critical hit chance" – a powerful move with a cooldown. Their passive might be "Master Gunner: this ship's cannon reload time is reduced by 10%". The strength and role of these abilities push players to combine the right captain with the right ship: a navigator-type captain might shine on a fast sloop, whereas a disciplinarian Admiral might bolster a big battleship.

Crew Chain (Synergy) System: In addition to the captain, each ship can have a **crew roster** – for example, 3 crew slots: one for First Mate, one for Navigator, one for Gunnery Chief (or other thematic roles). These crew members can either be generic upgrades or actual collectible characters as well (depending on scope). The **Crew Chain** concept means certain captains have **linked crew members** that, if assigned together, create enhanced effects. This works akin to a synergy or set bonus. For example, Captain "Aurora Black", a pirate queen character, might have a linked First Mate "Calico Jim" and Navigator "One-Eyed Ella" who are part of her legendary crew; if the player manages to also recruit those crew and assign them to Aurora's ship, it could unlock a chain bonus like "**Crew of the Black Flag**" – giving +15% damage and a special ability where the first hit in combat deals bonus damage. If only some of them are present, maybe smaller bonuses apply. This encourages collecting specific crew related to each captain. It's similar to synergy bonuses in other games where deploying officers of the same group boosts a stat ⁵, but framed narratively as legendary crews reuniting.

Additionally, even without specific named combos, crew can provide class-based synergy. Armada could implement a system like **Officer Classes** (say Tactician, Brawler, Support), where having one of each class in your ship's crew gives a general buff ⁵ (reflecting a well-rounded crew). Conversely, stacking all crew of the same faction as the captain might amplify the captain's ultimate ability further. This is directly inspired by systems like Star Trek Fleet Command's crew synergy ⁵, adapted to our naval theme.

Crew Progression: Crew members, if they are collectible units, would have their own level or maybe just provide fixed bonuses. More simply, crew could be treated as gear for the captain – e.g. you "equip" a crew card to a slot, and it gives a stat boost. High-quality crew cards (like a veteran gunner) give bigger bonuses. Crew might also be upgradable (combine duplicates to increase their effect). However, to keep focus, we might limit heavy progression to captains and ships, with crew being a lighter system.

Relationship to Ships: A key design is that **captains can be moved between ships**, but each captain might have a preferred ship type (perhaps giving an extra bonus when on their favored class). For instance, an Admiral character might give +5% cannon damage on any ship, but if placed on a Ship-of-the-Line class, that bonus doubles. This way, players consider which captain-ship pairing maximizes strengths. Before battle, the player chooses which captains to assign to the 3 active ships (likely from those already attached, but there could be a pre-battle assignment phase if needed).

Overall, the Captains & Crew system injects a **personalized RPG layer** into Armada. It's not just about ships as interchangeable units; the human (or otherwise) leaders bring distinctive flavor and tactics. Players can mix and match captains and ships to find potent combinations (a bit like combining heroes and units in other games). This system also fuels long-term **collection goals**: even when the fleet of ships might be stable, there's always a new famous captain on the horizon to recruit, or a legendary first mate to complete a crew chain. By investing in captains, players indirectly invest in their fleet's power, and by gathering crews, they unlock the full potential of those captains. This interplay ensures depth and progression longevity, as there's always another character to train or synergy to pursue.

Progression Systems and Economy

Armada's progression is multi-layered, combining **account progression**, **ship progression**, and **captain progression** with a steady economy to support them. The design goal is to provide constant goals – both short-term (next ship upgrade, next level for a captain) and long-term (unlocking a new ship class, completing a campaign arc).

Player Account Progression: As players complete missions and participate in activities, they gain overall **Account XP** (or perhaps "Navy Renown"). This could correspond to an account level that unlocks features (for example, Harbor level gates some content – e.g. PvP unlocks at level 5, raids at level 10) and rewards. Each account level-up might give bonus resources or a loot chest. This ensures that as players play broadly, they see a sense of progression even outside specific ships/captains.

Ship Progression: Discussed earlier, each ship has upgrade levels for components and an overall tier. Upgrading costs resources and possibly time (a build timer that can be sped up, common in base-building games, though we might avoid too many timers to keep focus on strategy). To prevent a single ship from being overpowered, a system of diminishing returns or an upgrade cap based on player progress might exist (e.g. you can't upgrade a starter sloop to max level until your account or harbor is at a certain level). Additionally, unlocking *new ships* often represents major progression milestones. For instance, the campaign might award a new ship blueprint at certain points, or the Harbor's Shipyard can research new ship designs once prerequisites are met. This feels similar to a tech tree: **the underlying principle of progression is moving from lower-tier ships to higher-tier ships** as your capabilities grow ⁶.

Captain Progression: As detailed, captains level up through use or training. Higher-level captains significantly improve a ship's performance (we may tie a portion of a ship's stats to the captain's level to reinforce that, e.g. the captain's Navigation skill adds to ship speed, Gunnery adds to accuracy). This means even if a ship is maxed out in upgrades, putting a low-level captain on it won't realize its full potential – encouraging players to train their captains too. Conversely, a high-level captain can somewhat compensate for an under-upgraded ship. Promotions through shards add a **collection grind** element – players can replay specific content or events that drop the shards for their favorite captain, or acquire them via the store, ensuring a monetization hook but one that can be earned as well.

Resource Economy: The main resources include: - **Gold (Coins):** Common currency for general use, such as basic upgrades, crew hiring wages, etc. - **Wood, Iron, Canvas, Gunpowder (Materials):** Used for ship upgrades and building harbor structures. E.g., upgrading hull uses wood and iron, upgrading sails uses canvas, upgrading cannons uses iron and gunpowder. - **Captain XP Items (Logs):** Represent training or experiences that can be consumed to give captains XP outside of battle. - **Captain Shards:** Specific to each captain, as discussed, used to promote them. - **Crew Tokens:** A currency or item used to recruit random crew members (if we implement a crew gacha or store). - **Premium Currency (Gems/Doubloons):** Purchased with real money, can be spent to either buy cosmetics, convert into other resources, or speed up build timers. Given our monetization stance, premium currency is mostly for convenience and cosmetics.

Resource generation and sinks are balanced to encourage play: Daily quests and missions give a steady influx, whereas upgrades consume them. There might be a **soft energy system** in the form of "Supplies" or "Ship provisions" that limit how many missions can be run in a short time, which is refillable by premium currency if needed – a common mobile mechanic, but it should be lenient for core loops.

Upgrading Harbor Buildings: The base itself has progression – upgrading the Shipyard might allow higher tier upgrades for ships, upgrading the Tavern might increase the rate of getting new quests or improve co-op matching, etc. These upgrades cost resources and potentially time. It ties into the feeling of growing one's home base and indirectly improving efficiency (like a higher level harbor might produce a small trickle of free resources daily, or reduce the cost of certain actions via “economy upgrades”).

Difficulty Progression: As players progress, enemy AI and stats scale up. The campaign ensures a learning curve – early missions are tutorial-like, but later missions might have enemy fleets with advanced tactics (AI that focuses fire, uses abilities intelligently). We will incorporate a **recommended power level** indicator for missions so players can gauge if their fleet is ready. If under-leveled, players can replay previous missions on harder difficulties or do side missions to grind resources and XP.

Pacing: A midcore strategy game like this typically expects the player to engage in a core loop of ~30 minutes a day (or more for enthusiasts). Each upgrade might take a day or two of resource farming, each captain promotion might take a week of effort for high rarities, etc., to keep long-term goals. However, with multiple parallel progress paths (story, ships, captains, base), there's always something to do.

This progression system is designed to be **deep but manageable**. It provides clear goals (upgrade that ship, level that captain, beat that mission) and the means to achieve them through regular play, while also creating opportunities for monetization (speeding up progress, buying a missing resource). Importantly, no single progression vector (ship or captain) alone dominates – players need to advance on all fronts to succeed, which naturally paces the game and prevents hitting a hard wall if one aspect lags behind.

PvE Modes: Campaign and Raids

The **PvE content** in Armada is rich and varied, anchored by the main **Campaign Mode** and supplemented by special missions and raid encounters.

Campaign Mode: This is the core story mode of Armada, consisting of multiple chapters (arcs). Each chapter is a sequence of missions with narrative interludes. Missions have increasing difficulty and various objectives:

- **Skirmish Battles:** Straight-up fleet vs fleet combat with the player's 3 ships against a set of enemy ships. These are common missions that test combat fundamentals.
- **Escort/Defense:** The player must protect an allied ship (like a merchant or an important NPC vessel) from waves of attackers for a certain number of turns or until it exits the map. This introduces defensive play and positioning challenges.
- **Assault Sieges:** The player's fleet might have to attack a fortified position (like shore batteries or a harbor fort) along with AI-controlled allies. These battles involve static defenses and perhaps infinite enemy reinforcements until objectives are destroyed, pushing the player to take out the fort under pressure.
- **Chase/Capture:** A mission where the enemy tries to flee. The player must disable or corner a specific ship before it escapes off the map. High speed and maybe special chain-shot ammo (to slow the enemy) become crucial.
- **Boss Battles:** At the arc's end, a boss fight occurs. Boss fights in campaign are often multi-stage battles. For example, fighting the **Dread Pirate Lord** might first involve defeating his escort ships, then focusing on his powerful flagship which has a unique mechanic (e.g. it could summon reinforcement or has rotating invulnerable sides except one weak point). Some bosses might even involve environmental hazards (stormy weather reducing visibility, or navigating around rocks).

Each mission, when completed, gives a star or medal rating (commonly 3-star system) based on performance (like remaining HP, completing sub-objectives). These stars could unlock bonus rewards or

allow access to later chapters. Players can replay missions to get missed rewards or improve rating, but narrative-wise they progress linearly.

Side Quests: In addition to the main storyline missions, there could be optional side quests triggered by visiting certain NPCs in the Harbor or reaching specific points in the campaign. These side quests expand lore and often reward extra resources or a new captain/crew. For instance, a side quest might involve helping a scientist character test a new cannon (an excuse for a challenge mission where you only control one ship with a super cannon and must sink enemies in one shot each).

Dynamic Missions: To keep PvE engaging outside the scripted campaign, Armada can include dynamic missions. Examples: - **Bounties:** A daily system where a random enemy fleet configuration is generated (with difficulty scaled to player power) and players hunt them for bounty rewards. - **Expeditions:** Send one of your ships (under AI control, somewhat like a dispatch mission) on an expedition that takes a few hours in real time and yields resources or possibly story snippets. This uses spare ships and is a passive PvE element.

Co-op Raids (PvE): Mentioned in Pillars, these are special PvE events where multiple players participate. In detail, a co-op raid might work like: - A giant enemy (say the **Leviathan Sea Serpent**) appears as an event. Players can queue up in co-op teams of 2-3 in real time, or individually contribute damage asynchronously. - If co-op synchronous: the players' fleets appear together on the map, and they coordinate in real-time turns to fight the AI boss. The boss might have huge HP and deal heavy damage, so teamwork is needed to survive and deal optimal damage (like one player uses a defensive buff to shield allies while another unleashes offense). - If asynchronous/global: the boss has a global HP pool. Each time a player fights it in their own instance (with perhaps a damage cap or time limit), they chip away at the global pool. Rewards are given based on personal damage contribution and if the community/guild fully defeats the boss by event end, bonus rewards unlock. This style ensures everyone can participate on their own schedule.

PvE Events and Difficulty Levels: Over time, we can introduce higher difficulty modes for PvE content: - **Hard Mode Campaign:** Once a chapter is completed, a harder version unlocks (enemies have better AI and stats, maybe additional enemy ships or trickier win conditions) for veteran players to retry for extra rewards. - **Raid Difficulty Tiers:** The co-op events could have tiers (Normal, Heroic, Mythic) that scale up the challenge and require progressively more optimized fleets (and group coordination). - **Endless or Survival Mode:** A mode where the player sees how many enemy waves they can survive with their fleet, primarily for leaderboard glory or achievement.

PvE content is planned to be continually expanded via Live Ops. New chapters in the narrative, special event missions (perhaps a limited-time crossover or holiday mission with a fun twist, like fighting ghost ships on Halloween), and rotating co-op bosses keep PvE from getting stale.

Ultimately, the PvE modes aim to cater to both **story-focused players** (who want an epic narrative campaign and handcrafted scenarios) and **challenge-driven players** (who relish perfecting hard fights, grinding for rewards, and teaming up against big bads). By offering a variety of mission types and difficulties, Armada's PvE should remain a compelling cornerstone of the game that complements the PvP for a rounded experience.

PvP Mode: Duels and Fleet Battles

The **Player vs Player** component of Armada adds a competitive arena for those seeking to test their fleets against others. As outlined, PvP is primarily **asynchronous**, meaning direct real-time battles against live opponents are not required – instead, players challenge the saved fleets of others, with AI controlling the defense side.

PvP Duels: The basic mode is a 3v3 fleet duel. A player selects their attacking fleet (3 ships + captains) and is matched against another player's **defense fleet**. The defense fleet consists of the opponent's chosen 3 ships, their captains, and importantly their pre-set behavior script or formation. We allow the defending player some control over AI behavior via a simple strategy setting (for example, defense stance could be Aggressive – engage the closest enemy, or Evasive – try to keep distance and kite, etc., or even ship-specific toggles like "Ship A focus on enemy flagship"). This adds a layer of skill in setting a good defense formation.

When a match is made (through a matchmaking system), the battle plays out as if it were a normal combat – the attacker issues orders for their ships each turn, while the defending AI follows its logic. Because it's AI, the defender offline can't adapt on the fly, but a well-configured defense can surprise careless attackers. After the battle, the outcome (win/loss) is reported. The attacking player gains PvP points for a win (and maybe a small amount even for a loss to encourage participation), and the defender might lose points if their defense was defeated. To prevent abuse, there could be a limit to how many times a single player can be attacked within a timeframe or a revenge system.

Ranking and Leagues: PvP will have a ranking system (e.g. **trophies** or an elo-like rating). To make it accessible, we might have **leagues** (Bronze, Silver, Gold, etc., or ranks like Commodore, Admiral etc.). Players climb the ladder by winning battles. At the end of a **PvP season** (which could be monthly), they receive rewards based on their highest rank achieved. Rewards typically include cosmetic titles or badges, some premium currency, and resources. This gives an incentive to compete. There could also be a **Hall of Fame leaderboard** for top players globally each season.

Fleet Loadouts & Meta: Because defense fleets are fixed when set, players can scout an opponent (maybe seeing their ship types and captain levels before committing to a fight) and then choose their attacking fleet accordingly. This introduces a meta-game of fleet composition. If a certain ship type is very common on defense, players might find counters for it (e.g. lots of players using heavy ships might be weak to a fast fire-ship strategy). We will continuously balance ships and captains to avoid any dominant strategy. Regular introduction of new captains or ships can also shift the meta and keep PvP encounters fresh.

PvP Energy & Matching: To avoid excessive grinding by a few, there could be a limit like **PvP tickets** (say you have 5 PvP battles free per day, then you need to spend a resource or wait). Matchmaking should try to pair you with others of similar trophy count or power level. Optionally, we can let players **spar with friends or guildmates** for practice (friendly matches that don't affect rank).

Asynchronous Guild Wars (Future Expansion): In Live Ops strategy we might plan a larger PvP format: guild vs guild wars. These could work by having each guild member's defense fleet placed on a map or war board, and opposing guilds have a few days to attack as many as possible, scoring points. It's something to consider post-launch to deepen PvP and guild interaction.

Real-time PvP Possibility: While core design is async, we might implement a **duel mode** where two friends can battle in real-time (both online) for fun. This would be a more niche, connection-dependent feature but could be exciting for live streaming events or tournaments. However, it's not required for the core loop.

In all, PvP in Armada should be **strategic and fair**. The asynchronous model ensures everyone can participate at convenience and that outcomes are more about preparation and strategy than twitch reactions or connection quality. It integrates seamlessly with the progression – you fight with the ships and captains you've been developing, giving another purpose to leveling them. PvE teaches the skills and builds the roster, and PvP is where players prove their mastery. This competitive outlet will drive some players to invest more in perfecting their fleet, feeding into the progression loops and social pride of showing off one's mighty armada to the world.

Harbor & Base Hub Systems

The **Harbor** (player base) is more than a backdrop; it's an interactive space that centralizes all non-battle gameplay. Designing the harbor involves both UI/UX considerations and gameplay mechanics (building upgrades, resource management).

Harbor Layout & Navigation: The harbor is depicted as a coastal town or port. Different functional areas are visually represented by buildings or ships at dock: - The **Shipyards**: A large drydock or construction area where ships can be built/upgraded. Tapping this brings up the Ship upgrade menu and tech tree. - The **Tavern**: A lively inn by the docks, representing social features and recruitment. Tapping opens the captain recruitment interface (perhaps showing a list of captains available or a gacha roll screen), as well as chat and guild menu. - The **Market/Trading Post**: A marketplace stall or harbormaster's office where the shop is. Here players buy cosmetics, resource packs, or exchange currencies. - The **Admiralty Hall**: A grand building (or the flagship anchored at port) that acts as the player's office – here you arrange fleet compositions, view your collection (ship library, captain roster), and access high-level info (like stats, achievements). - The **Mission Board**: A notice board near the tavern or a harbormaster's map that when tapped opens the PvE mission selection screen (campaign map, raid events, etc). - **Guild Hall**: If guilds are prominent, a building with your guild's banner could be present, which when tapped opens guild chat, guild tasks, and co-op event info.

The UI should allow quick navigation by tapping these areas. There will also be a simple menu bar for those who prefer direct UI icons (e.g. an icon for Ships, one for Captains, etc., for quick access without exploring the harbor every time).

Upgrading Harbor Buildings: Each building in the harbor can have levels. Upgrading a building costs resources and possibly time (like constructing improvements). These upgrades yield benefits: - Upgrading Shipyards might allow building higher tier ships or reduce upgrade times/costs by X%. - Upgrading Tavern might increase the chances of finding higher rarity captains (i.e. better recruitment odds) or unlock more quest slots/crew hiring slots. - Upgrading Market could unlock more items in the shop or better exchange rates. - Upgrading storage buildings (implied existence: warehouses) increases resource caps (how much wood/iron you can hold). - Possibly upgrading defenses (cannons on the port) which could tie into PvP if players can raid each other's harbors – but that's an extra feature to consider carefully.

These improvements give a **town-building feel**, similar to games like Clash of Clans or XCOM's base, but on a lighter scale since the main game is battles. Players have a reason to invest in their harbor: it yields long-

term efficiency and sometimes gates progress (e.g., you need a Level 3 Shipyard to upgrade a ship beyond a certain level, ensuring players engage with base building).

Social Interaction in Harbor: When connected to the internet, the harbor can display social elements. Perhaps docked at one side could be a friend's ship visiting (purely cosmetic but shows your friend's name and ship skin). In the tavern, you might see avatar icons of guildmates currently online (clicking could open their profile or a private chat). We want the harbor to feel not only like your personal space but also a meeting ground. Global chat might be accessible via a chat bar at the top or as speech bubble pop-ups near the tavern, giving a diegetic feeling of sailors gossiping.

Customization: The harbor itself can be cosmetically customized to a degree – another sink for cosmetic monetization. E.g., players could change the banner flying on the fort, add cosmetic props (a statue commemorating a victory, different color roofs, etc.). This doesn't affect gameplay but adds personal touch.

Resource Production: Some harbor structures might passively produce resources. Perhaps a **Lumber Mill** at the harbor edge produces a little wood per hour, a **Foundry** produces iron, etc. Players collect these periodically. It's a minor income that complements active play. Upgrading these structures increases output. Alternatively, instead of separate structures, the harbor itself could have a concept of prosperity that yields periodic resource drops.

Harbor Defenses (Optional): If we consider adding base raids (players raiding each other's harbors for resources asynchronously), then harbor defenses like cannons or walls would come into play and require upgrading. However, this might complicate the design and overlap with the fleet PvP. Unless it's a core feature, we may skip direct base raiding to focus PvP on fleet battles, which are more unique to our game.

User Experience: The harbor view should not become cumbersome. We'll likely allow players to disable the fancy 3D harbor view for a simpler UI if they want quick navigation (maybe a list menu), but the harbor is a showcase for art and a place to immerse in the world, so first-time and regular players will enjoy seeing their domain flourish. The harbor will transition between day/night cycles or weather changes possibly (mostly cosmetic, or could tie to events).

In essence, the Harbor is the **central hub tying every system**: it's where you go between battles to do everything else – upgrade, recruit, socialize, shop. By gamifying it with upgrades and making it visually representative of progress (a bustling, well-fortified port means a high-level player), it also serves as a **metaphor for your progress** in the world. New players have a humble cove; veterans command a grand port city.

Art & UI Direction

The art direction of Armada merges **historical authenticity with painterly fantasy**. The visual style draws inspiration from classic naval oil paintings of the Age of Sail, as seen in dramatic depictions of 18th-century sea battles. In practice, this translates to a **painterly art style** for the game's overall look – textures and environments have brushstroke-like detail and rich, saturated colors, giving the sense that the world is a living painting. Ships are rendered with realistic proportions and rigging, but with a slight stylization to match the fantasy epic tone (for example, exaggerated sails or figureheads to make silhouettes distinct and visually appealing on small screens).

World and Environment Art: The ocean is a key “character” – it’s rendered with dynamic shaders showing waves and reflections, leaning more towards artistic impression than photorealism (to avoid performance drain on mobile). We might use a stylized approach to water, with visible wave strokes and whitecaps that look hand-painted. Islands, ports, and forts in the environment similarly will have that painted concept art vibe when seen from the overhead view. Color palettes likely shift with regions and moods: a bright turquoise shallow sea for a tropical chapter, versus a stormy gray-black sea under a thunderstorm for a dramatic boss battle.

Ships and Characters: Ships are detailed with period-accurate elements (masts, sails, cannons) so enthusiasts recognize the types, but embellished with unique color schemes and decorations to differentiate factions. We ensure that at a glance, a player can tell a Royal Navy vessel from a pirate ship – through sail colors, flags, and hull design motifs. With cosmetic skins, we might lean into fantasy a bit more (e.g. flame-patterned sails, or glowing runes on a ghost ship hull for an event skin) while keeping the base designs grounded. Characters (captains and crew) are illustrated in a slightly exaggerated heroic style – think along the lines of **illustrated card art** for captains in the UI. They wear outfits inspired by 17th-18th century naval uniforms, pirate garb, etc., with a touch of fantasy (like an Admiral might have a magical compass on his belt). Since the game is top-down in battles, you won’t see characters moving on ships, but their portraits and any dialog scenes will showcase this art. We plan 2D portraits with dynamic lighting and perhaps some animation (parallax or small movements) for storytelling.

User Interface: The UI needs to be **clean and thematic**. We adopt a nautical design motif: parchment scroll backgrounds for menus, compass and sextant icons, rope and wood textures framing panels. However, clarity is paramount for a strategy game, so we avoid overly ornate designs that could clutter. For example, health bars might look like little segmented ship hulls, ability icons might be housed in cannonball-like circular frames. The primary color scheme of UI could be deep blues and golds (navy and brass feel) to evoke naval tradition. Interactive elements are sized for mobile – buttons not too small – and we will support both phone and tablet aspect ratios.

In combat, the UI overlays (like movement arrows, attack range cones) will be visually consistent with the art style (perhaps looking like they’re drawn with chalk or ink on the “world”), but also distinct enough to be seen clearly. Ability buttons will have illustrated icons (like a powder keg for an explosive shot ability) and use cool-down timers shown as radial sweeps.

Feedback and Effects: Visual effects in battles (muzzle flashes, cannon smoke, water splashes) are done in a stylized fashion. Cannon smoke, for instance, might billow in a cloudy shape that dissipates like ink in water – visually pleasing and not too opaque so as to hide gameplay. Hits on ships will produce particle effects of wood splinters and fire if critical. We keep gore minimal; crew deaths are not shown explicitly – sinking ships will maybe show tiny figures diving overboard (in a stylized minimal way) for flavor but nothing graphic. If fantasy elements like magic or mythical beings are present, their effects (like a sea monster’s attack or a mystical fog) will integrate with the painterly aesthetic, possibly using glowing particles combined with traditional effects.

Camera and View: The default view is top-down or high-angle to see the tactical layout. We may allow slight zooming or rotation, but likely a locked orientation for fairness. However, for **cinematic moments** (like when a boss ship appears or a finishing broadside volley that sinks the last enemy), we could momentarily cut to a more dynamic angle or a quick close-up, using in-game 3D models, to emphasize the action. These should be used sparingly and with option to skip, to not disrupt gameplay frequently.

Performance Considerations: The art style's painterly approach has a benefit – we can use slightly lower-poly models and let the texture style hide some lack of ultra-fine geometric detail, maintaining performance on mobile. We will optimize for mid-range devices, with settings to reduce water shader complexity or particle count if needed. The UI will be tested for different screen sizes, ensuring readability (for instance, text on a phone must be large enough). We use vector art or high-res assets for 2D elements to scale nicely.

Audio & Music (briefly): The audio design (though not visual art, it complements it) will aim for immersive and epic. Thundering cannon sounds, the creaking of ships, and a rousing orchestral soundtrack with snare drums and strings to evoke the Age of Sail era. Possibly dynamic music that swells in boss fights and calms in harbor. Sound effects have a realistic basis but may be enhanced for dramatic effect (a bit of bass boost on cannon fire, etc.).

The intended result is that players feel transported to an alternate Age of Sail – it should feel **authentic yet enchanted**, like a classic painting come to life. The UI and art invite players into a world that is **historically flavored but not dull** – full of color, grandeur, and the romance of naval adventure. This high-quality art direction also helps position Armada as a **premium experience** in the mobile space, appealing to players who value production value alongside gameplay depth.

Narrative Overview

Armada's narrative unfolds in a richly imagined alternate history, blending real Age-of-Sail elements with original fantasy twists. The story is structured in a series of **campaign arcs**, each akin to a novel or season of a show, providing clear rising and falling action while contributing to an overarching saga.

Setting & World: The game world resembles the Age of Sail era (17th-18th century technology) but is set in a fictional globe with several major powers: - The **Aurorian Empire**: A dominant naval superpower (loosely inspired by the British Empire) known for its disciplined Royal Armada and advanced shipbuilding. They control numerous colonies and trade routes. - The **Coalition of Free Cities**: A federation of merchant cities and smaller nations (inspired by Dutch/Portuguese seafaring nations) that band together to resist imperial control, valuing freedom of the seas. - The **Crimson Republic (Pirates)**: A loose faction of pirates and privateers who've formed their own republic on a hidden island. They are both antagonists and unlikely allies at times – not outright evil, but driven by profit and freedom. - The **Ancient Order of Leviathan** (fantasy twist): A secretive faction or cult that has knowledge of mythical sea creatures and arcane weather magic. They lurk in the background, seeking to awaken powers beneath the sea to upset the world order (they might be the cause of the "light fantasy" events like ghost ships or krakens).

The player character assumes the role of a **young captain** whose initial allegiance can be chosen (perhaps at start you pick origin: ex-Imperial Navy, or independent privateer, etc., which slightly affects starting story or captain). Regardless, they quickly find themselves at the nexus of conflict among these powers.

Plot Arc Summaries: - **Arc 1: Maiden Voyage.** The player's home port (maybe a small Aurorian colony or a Free City harbor, depending on chosen background) is attacked by a notorious pirate captain working for the Crimson Republic. The player rallies a defense with an old ship and a couple of trusty crew (introducing initial captains). This arc is about personal stakes – defending home and learning the ropes of command. The climax sees the player face the pirate captain in a 1v1 ship duel (a boss fight), earning a first major victory. However, they discover evidence the pirates were armed with unusually powerful weaponry from an unknown benefactor. - **Arc 2: Tides of War.** War erupts between the Aurorian Empire and the Coalition of

Free Cities due to a trade dispute (orchestrated by hidden hands). The player, now proven, is enlisted (or contracts) into a larger fleet. They participate in key battles (mid-sized fleet engagements, perhaps controlling allied AI ships too). Through these missions, they meet rival captains from both sides – some becoming allies, others recurring enemies (like a rival enemy admiral character). This arc's narrative explores loyalty and the cost of war. It ends with a massive battle at sea (the player's fleet vs an enemy armada), which the player wins, but at high cost. In the aftermath, something strange occurs – e.g., as the enemy flagship sinks, a sea monster surfaces briefly, attacking indiscriminately before vanishing. This hints at the next arc's threat. - **Arc 3: Seas of Legend.** With the nations exhausted from war, reports come of ghost ship sightings and attacks by a legendary kraken. The Ancient Order of Leviathan steps from the shadows, aiming to destabilize all navies so they can seize power. The player might have to form an unlikely alliance (Imperials, Coalition, even pirates unite) to face this common threat. Missions involve hunting down these supernatural threats – e.g., fighting ghost ships (with unique mechanics like they regenerate if not finished quickly), navigating cursed fog, and eventually discovering the Order's base. The arc culminates in a battle against the Leviathan itself (a monstrous raid boss battle in campaign form) perhaps aided by allied fleets. Victory dispels the immediate threat, but key figures of the Order escape, setting stage for future content. - **Arc 4 and beyond:** Future arcs (post-launch updates) could introduce new regions (e.g., an Eastern-inspired archipelago with its own ships and captains, or the discovery of a new continent). Each would bring in new story arcs – maybe a treasure hunt race, or a civil war in the pirate republic that the player influences. The narrative would continue to escalate and then resolve in satisfying chunks, always keeping the player as a central hero whose choices and growing legend are acknowledged by NPCs (e.g., by Arc 4 NPCs call you "Admiral" and react to your prior deeds).

Characters: Throughout the campaign, a cast of supporting characters flesh out the story. Key allies might include: - **Captain Elena Fairwind:** The player's mentor figure, a seasoned Aurorian navy officer who provides guidance (tutorial-like advice) and moral centering. Possibly sacrifice or retire dramatically in an arc to drive emotional impact. - **Ryland the Red:** A brash pirate ally from the Crimson Republic who starts as an antagonist but grows to respect the player and can join as a captain in later arc (everyone loves a roguish antihero). - **Admiral Marcus Gray:** The rival enemy admiral during Arc 2 from the Coalition side, who begrudgingly allies with you in Arc 3 against the Order, offering a redemption arc or at least mutual respect. - **High Priestess Seraphine:** Leader of the Ancient Order, a recurring villain with a cool demeanor and mysterious powers. Possibly a boss to defeat or maybe even a capturable character in a future storyline.

These characters have their own motivations and may appear in dialogue scenes between missions. The story will be delivered via illustrated cutscenes or dialogue text boxes (with portrait art) before and after missions. Important choices might occasionally be given (for flavor, e.g. sparing a defeated enemy or not), though these won't hugely branch the main story but can affect minor outcomes (like which captain joins your crew later).

Narrative Tone: The writing style is **mature and serious** with an epic flavor. We emphasize the high-stakes nature of naval warfare – sacrifice, duty, camaraderie among crew, and the brutality of cannon warfare. But we avoid being too grim; there's room for **swashbuckling adventure and heroism**. Light fantasy elements are included to surprise and wonder: ancient sea myths being real, a hint of magic used by certain characters (like a weather witch who can summon a storm). These are integrated in a way that feels like tall tales sailors might tell – just on the edge of believability in our world, but real in this one.

Throughout, the narrative gives context to gameplay goals: when you're tasked to, say, upgrade your fleet, it might be framed as "the Admiralty has commissioned you a new ship after your victory" etc. Each mission is justified in story, to avoid the feeling of filler. By the end of the campaign (as it stands initially), the player will have grown from a nobody to a renowned Admiral with alliances across nations, having faced both worldly and otherworldly threats – truly earning the game's title *Armada*. And of course, hooks will remain for more adventures to come in live updates (new enemy factions, emerging threats, etc., can always be introduced).

Monetization Strategy and Economy Details

Armada is designed as a **free-to-play** title with a monetization strategy focused on fairness, player goodwill, and longevity. The guiding principle is to **monetize cosmetics and convenience**, not raw power, aligning with the "cosmetic-first" pillar.

Primary Revenue Streams: 1. **Cosmetic Items:** As discussed, players can purchase cosmetic customizations for their ships and possibly captains. This includes sails with unique designs, hull paint schemes, decorative prow/figureheads, special visual effects (e.g. different colored cannon flare or a cosmetic aura for your flagship). These cosmetics confer **no gameplay advantage** ⁷, but allow for personalization. They can be sold individually or in bundles (for example, a \$4.99 bundle with a full ship skin set themed around a nation or holiday). New cosmetics will be added regularly, often tying into events (e.g. a spooky sail design during Halloween event). The goal is to entice players to express themselves and show off in PvP or to friends.

1. **Premium Currency (Doubloons):** Players can buy Doubloons with real money. Doubloons serve as a flexible currency – they can be spent on a variety of things for convenience: speeding up ship upgrade timers, purchasing missing resources or captain shards directly, extra attempts at events, etc. We ensure that anything buyable with Doubloons can also be obtained through play (so it's pay-to-speed-up, not pay-to-exclusive). Doubloons can also likely buy cosmetics (for players who grind some premium currency via events or minor purchases).
2. **Captain/Crew Recruitment (Gacha-lite):** Depending on design choice, we might monetize the acquisition of new Captains or crew via a randomized "Recruit Chest" or tavern draw. For example, a player can spend a certain currency (earned slowly in game or bought) to get a random captain shard or crew member. However, to keep things cosmetic-first, the key is that all core captains can be acquired through gameplay (like campaign rewards or events) and the gacha mainly accelerates progression or provides variety. Another approach: high-rarity captains might be introduced via events and then later made widely available, avoiding a strictly paywalled character. The **monetization in this system is akin to hero collectors** but toned down to not require spending to enjoy the game.
3. **Battle Pass (Season Pass):** A monthly or bi-monthly **Armada Pass** could be offered. This is a popular monetization method in midcore games. The pass would have a free track and a premium track. By completing daily/weekly challenges (which align with normal gameplay, like "Win 5 PvP battles" or "Collect 100 wood"), players increase their pass level, earning rewards. Free track gives basic resources, while premium (maybe ~\$9.99 per season) yields extra rewards including exclusive cosmetics, a chunk of premium currency, perhaps a unique captain or crew member at the end. The premium track itemization will focus on cosmetics and convenience (e.g. some extra upgrade mats),

not huge power boosts that non-payers miss. This also drives engagement with the content cadence.

4. **Direct Resource/Booster Packs:** For players who want to progress faster, we'll offer packs such as "Shipbuilder's Crate" – containing a large amount of wood, iron, and some ship upgrade parts, or "Captain's Bundle" – XP tomes and a few shards for a selection of captains. These are priced at various tiers (\$0.99 up to large \$49.99 packs) to cater to different spending. Again, these don't give anything exclusive, just speed up growth. There may also be **time-limited offers** (like after finishing a chapter, an offer pops: "Congrats Admiral! Here's a one-time offer to boost your new fleet" with a discount on a resource bundle).

Retention and Monetization Balance: We incorporate soft monetization tactics that don't force a purchase but encourage one: - **Stamina/Energy system:** If we have an energy mechanic for missions, we'll provide plenty for free, but heavy players might buy an energy refill with premium currency to keep playing. - **Watch Ad for small reward:** Possibly include an opt-in ad system (like watch a 30s ad for a few premium currency or to slightly speed a build). However, given our target is midcore/hardcore, we might minimize ads to keep immersion. - **VIP or Subscription:** Another model could be a monthly subscription that gives daily goodies (like a daily injection of premium currency and slight boosts). Some players like predictable value. If included, it should be priced reasonably and not give anything that others can't get (just quantity convenience).

No Pay-to-Win Commitment: To uphold this, we ensure that: - No exclusive top-tier ships are sold for cash. All powerful ships must be earned by play. We might sell a lower-tier ship for convenience or as a starter pack (like a slightly better than starter ship to help new players, which is common), but it won't trump what free players can eventually get. - Captains might have time-limited exclusivity if introduced in a paid manner, but eventually become available to everyone through in-game means. Or if a monetized character exists, there's an alternative free way to get them later. - Matchmaking in PvP accounts for power, so a spender doesn't simply stomp a non-spender; they'll be matched with similar strength fleets. - Cosmetic purchases, while our main revenue, might have to be priced attractively since midcore players only pay if they love the game. We might include the ability to earn some cosmetics via gameplay too (so payers can shortcut or get premium variants, but everyone can personalize to some degree).

Economy Monitoring: We will closely watch the in-game economy via analytics. If certain resources bottleneck progress too harshly (causing frustration unless spending), we adjust drop rates or event rewards. Live Ops can offer occasional generous events (like double resource weekends, or a gift on game anniversary) to keep goodwill. An overly stingy economy might boost short-term monetization but will hurt retention, which we want to avoid for longevity.

Whale Accommodations: For the big spenders ("whales"), cosmetics provide a sink (some could be very rare and expensive cosmetic sets). We can also allow direct purchase of missing shards etc., with diminishing returns (so someone can indeed max everything by spending a lot, but they'll mostly match with other maxed players, so it doesn't ruin others' experience). The key is whales might pay to accelerate, but we want them to spend on looking unique and having breadth (collection), not on a single overpowered item.

In summary, the monetization is modeled to be sustainable and respectful: **players should feel good about spending** because it either makes their fleet look awesome or saves them time, not because they're

forced to pay to overcome a paywall. By focusing on cosmetics and smart optional purchases, Armada aims to build a loyal community that supports the game over time, rather than quick one-off transactions. This aligns with modern trends where cosmetic monetization can be highly lucrative when the game itself is competitive and skill-based ⁷, and it preserves the game's integrity and appeal to our target strategy gamers.

Core Loop Breakdown

Armada's core gameplay loop is designed to engage players in a cycle of **planning, battling, upgrading, and expanding**. Below is a step-by-step breakdown of the typical loop a player would go through in a play session:

- 1. Plan & Prepare (Harbor Phase):** Upon logging in, the player starts at their Harbor. They will **collect any idle rewards** (resource production from harbor buildings, daily login bonus, etc.). Then they check current objectives: daily missions, campaign progression, or an ongoing event. The player **chooses an activity** to undertake (say a campaign mission or a PvP match) and prepares accordingly. Preparation might involve tweaking their fleet – e.g., switching a ship or captain to better suit the upcoming mission's enemy type, ensuring all ships are repaired (if there's durability or damage persistence, which we might or might not have), and using spare resources to perform any quick upgrades that could help (like "upgrade cannons to level 3 before this tough fight"). This planning stage gives the player a chance to strategize and invest in their fleet.
- 2. Engage in Battle (Mission/Battle Phase):** The player enters the chosen battle. For example, they start a **Campaign mission**. They go through the **turn-based combat** as described earlier, issuing orders, maneuvering, and using abilities. This is the high-engagement moment of the loop where the core gameplay shines. The battle might last a few minutes (mobile-friendly length, perhaps 3-5 minutes for a normal mission, up to 10 for a boss or PvP war). The outcome is either victory or defeat. If defeat, the loop might branch to learning and adjusting (the player might need to grind or rethink tactics), but assuming victory for the loop:
- 3. Earn Rewards (Reward Phase):** Upon victory, the player receives **immediate rewards**: gold, materials, maybe a random loot drop (like a new crew card or a shard for a captain). They also earn progression markers like Captain XP for those used in battle, and Account XP. If it's the first completion of that mission, there could be one-time rewards (e.g. a lump sum of resources or an unlock of a new ship/captain). There may also be a post-battle summary with a star rating if applicable. This phase is critical to give a sense of accomplishment – flashing "Mission Complete" and showing loot gained.
- 4. Upgrade & Progress (Growth Phase):** Back at the Harbor (or immediately via a post-battle prompt), the player will use the rewards to **upgrade their assets**. For instance, with the wood and iron gained, they might finish that cannon upgrade on their frigate. Or they gained enough captain XP to level up a captain, increasing their effectiveness. Perhaps they accumulated enough shards to promote a captain. This is the **incremental progression** step that makes the player stronger. It's satisfying to apply new upgrades and see stats improve or a progress bar move. If a new feature was unlocked (like a new ship or the next story chapter), this is where it's recognized (maybe the game notifies "New Ship Available: Brig unlocked!" prompting the player to build it if they have resources).

5. **Expand & Explore (Expansion Phase):** With upgrades done, new content likely opened up – the next campaign mission, a harder difficulty, or a PvP challenge now feasible. The player now has expanded options. This might involve making a **choice for the next loop**: continue the campaign story or perhaps do a different mode (maybe after a tough story battle, they decide to do a casual bounty mission or a PvP match for variety and extra loot). This phase in a session might also include **social interactions**: the player could check in on their guild chat, send a quick friendly PvP spar, or help a guild member's request (if a system exists like lending a ship or contributing to a guild project). These social touches keep them engaged and might prompt additional loops (like "oh, guildmate is doing the co-op raid, I'll join").
6. **Live Ops Engagement (Event Phase, occasionally):** If a limited-time event is running (e.g. a co-op raid or a time-limited challenge), the player will integrate that into their loop. For instance, after doing daily chores, they spend some time on the event (which might itself loop through battle->reward->upgrade). Live events often have their own mini-loop (like accumulate event currency to trade for rewards, encouraging repeated play). We ensure the game surfaces these events in the loop so players remember to participate (UI notifications, etc.).
7. **Monetization Touchpoints:** Within the loop, there are gentle prompts for monetization without breaking flow. After a battle loss, the game might offer a tip like "Upgrade your ship or get better crew" with a button that leads to the upgrade screen – on that screen, if the player lacks resources, a small shop prompt might offer them. Or if they are 1 shard short of promoting a captain, an in-game hint could suggest checking the Tavern (where they could roll for recruits). These are optional and ideally contextual. Also, as they progress, hitting a milestone could trigger an offer ("First PvP win pack: get extra gear for PvP"). The key is these are optional and ideally feel helpful rather than intrusive.
8. **Repeat or Rest:** After completing these tasks, the player either has more energy/time and goes for another cycle (perhaps now tries a PvP battle or a different mission), or if they've done all dailies and are satisfied, they log off. On logout, maybe a reminder like "Your ship upgrade will finish in 2 hours" encourages them to return later, or an upcoming event timer is shown.

To illustrate a concrete example of one loop: A player logs in at lunchtime, collects daily login rewards and sees a new campaign mission unlocked. They swap in a recently acquired fire ship because the mission hint says "lots of small enemy boats" (planning). They fight the mission, it's intense but they win, using their new captain's special at a clutch moment (battle). They get loot including a rare Captain shard and enough iron to finish a ship upgrade (rewards). They upgrade their ship's hull, and use some XP items to level their captain to 10 (upgrade progress). This increases their power, allowing them to now qualify for the weekly raid event (which required a certain power rating). They join a quick co-op raid attempt with guildmates (expansion to event). After that, they chat "GG" on guild chat, see an in-game news about next week's content, and log off feeling they progressed and contributed.

The **core loop** thus ensures a balance of **action (battle)** and **strategy (management/upgrades)** each session, wrapped in narrative or event context so it feels meaningful. It's structured to be **addictive** (in a positive way) by always giving something to look forward to – a new upgrade finishing in a bit, a next mission beckoning, a leaderboard to climb tomorrow. At the same time, it respects time – a player can complete meaningful progress in a short session, but also has enough depth to play longer if they want to optimize or do extra modes.

Technology & Platform Notes

Armada is being developed for **mobile platforms (iOS and Android)**, leveraging technologies best suited for cross-platform 3D strategy games.

Game Engine: We will use the **Unity engine** (as it's widely used for mobile 3D games and supports both iOS/Android with a single codebase). Unity's robust tools for 2D UI and 3D rendering will help create our painterly style through custom shaders and post-processing. It also offers good support for networking frameworks necessary for PvP and co-op.

(If not Unity, Unreal is a contender for high-fidelity visuals, but Unity's mobile optimizations and larger talent pool tilt the choice.)

Supported Devices: We target mid-to-high end smartphones from the last 4-5 years. Minimum requirements might be: - Android: OS 8.0+, 3 GB RAM, a mid-tier GPU (like Adreno 618 or equivalent). - iOS: iPhone 8 or later. We'll optimize to run at 30 FPS smoothly on these specs. Tablets are also supported with adaptive UI layouts (Unity's Canvas can anchor UI so it scales/adjusts to different aspect ratios).

Graphics & Performance: Given the semi-real-time nature of simultaneous turns, we ensure performance is stable during battle simulations. We'll incorporate options to toggle graphic levels (turn off extra effects, lower water shader quality) for lower devices. Memory management is critical as we have multiple ship models and effects – we use pooling for projectiles and ensure texture atlases for UI to reduce draw calls.

Networking: The game requires a **network connection** for most features (especially PvP and events) ¹². We'll use a client-server model. For synchronous co-op or any potential live PvP, a authoritative server approach is needed to prevent cheating and sync gameplay. Likely, we'll integrate a proven solution for turn-based MP – possibly Photon or a custom lightweight turn sync via cloud. Asynchronous PvP is simpler; it just needs to fetch opponent data and then report results to server. Data like fleets, upgrades, inventories are stored server-side to prevent hacking (common practice in F2P). We must also secure any competitive aspects with validation (e.g., if a battle result is reported that doesn't make sense, the server can reject it or flag).

Data & Analytics: We will instrument the game with analytics (using something like Firebase or Unity Analytics) to track player progression, level completion rates, monetization funnels, etc. This tech helps the Live Ops team adjust difficulty or economy on the fly. Additionally, A/B testing frameworks might be incorporated to optimize things like tutorial or offers.

Online Infrastructure: We anticipate a live service with potentially thousands (hopefully millions) of players, so a scalable backend is needed. Using cloud services (AWS/GCP/Azure) to host our game servers and databases is planned. We'll need a **login system** – possibly using platform accounts (Game Center, Google Play Games) combined with a custom account for cross-platform (allowing a user to play on iOS and Android with one account via email or Facebook linking).

Updates and Patch Delivery: Mobile games get updated frequently. We will use app store updates for core client changes, but also plan for asset bundles or downloadable content so we can push new chapters or ships without forcing a full app update each time (Unity's Addressables or similar can handle remote

content delivery). The app size we aim to keep moderate – maybe ~200 MB initial download – with additional content streamed as needed (so as not to deter initial downloads).

Device Features: We will support both touchscreen controls primarily, and possibly enable gamepad support for those who play on certain Android devices or iPad with a controller, though that's low priority. Haptic feedback can be used subtly (phone vibration when a broadside hits, for immersion). Push notifications will be implemented to remind players of events ("Your ships are repaired and ready for battle!" or "Raid starting in 1 hour!") – of course configurable by user.

Testing and Compatibility: The game will undergo testing on a range of devices (we'll maintain a list of at least 10-15 popular phone models to test on, covering low to high end). We also consider differences like notch displays or different aspect ratios – UI will anchor accordingly. Memory leaks or battery drain will be profiled; mobile sessions can be long so we want to manage battery usage (30 FPS cap, and maybe a battery saver graphical mode).

Security: We will implement measures against cheating: because it's competitive, some may try modding the client or using emulators with hacks. Server-side checks will validate outcomes (e.g., a ship can't have more HP than possible, a player can't earn infinite resources suddenly). We might employ easy-anticheat or our own detection for memory editing. Also, secure communications (HTTPS) for API calls to prevent packet tampering in transit. This is crucial for a fair PvP environment.

Platform Services: We'll integrate with platform-specific services as needed: for example, Apple Sign-In, Google Play Sign-In, achievements and leaderboards if relevant (though we have our own systems too), and in-app purchase SDKs for monetization. We must adhere to App Store and Play Store guidelines, especially regarding in-app purchase transparency and data privacy (we'll include a GDPR-compliant privacy policy, etc.).

Deployment and Updates: The tech stack includes version control (Git) for development, CI/CD pipelines for building and testing each update, and perhaps feature flags to enable/disable content server-side without new client (for live ops flexibility). We plan a **soft launch** in a smaller region to test technology at scale and iterate on network performance and device compatibility before a global launch.

In summary, the technology approach is to use proven engines and scalable backend solutions to deliver a smooth experience on mobile. We emphasize cross-platform availability (someone on Android can play with someone on iOS in co-op) and future-proofing content delivery. The platform notes reflect that we treat Armada as a living product that will receive frequent updates and must run reliably on the primary mobile ecosystems.

Live Ops Strategy

Armada's Live Operations strategy is key to keeping players engaged long-term and generating ongoing revenue. We plan a robust schedule of **events, updates, and community engagement** that provides a fresh experience month after month.

Content Release Cadence: As mentioned, we target **monthly content updates or events** ⁹. A tentative cadence might be: - **Major Update (Every 3 months):** Introduces a new campaign arc or chapter (adding

story missions, maybe a new region/faction), new ships and captains, and possibly a new gameplay feature (like a new PvP mode or guild feature). These are like expansions that can be hyped in advance. - **Minor Updates (Monthly in-between):** Each month that isn't a major drop will still have something new: for example, one month a limited-time event with unique gameplay variant, the next month a couple of new captains and a PvP season refresh, etc. - **Weekly/biweekly Events:** Smaller scale events to keep the routine – e.g., one week a resource-focused event (“Double rewards in missions this week”), another week a mini challenge (“Use only frigates in PvP to earn bonus points”).

Event Types: We will rotate through a variety of event types to appeal to different player motivations: - **Resource Boost Events:** For example, “Gold Rush Week” where daily missions grant extra gold, encouraging more play and helping players progress (good to alleviate any mid-game grind walls). - **Competition Events:** Like a PvP tournament or a ladder event where for a limited time there are extra rewards for climbing ranks, or a special PvP rule (all fleets have fog of war or some twist). - **Co-op Raid Events:** Possibly monthly, a new big raid boss as discussed. We can tie these to lore (“The Kraken returns!”) and cosmetics (“Defeat it to earn Kraken-themed sails”). - **Time-Limited Campaigns:** A short set of missions available for, say, two weeks with a self-contained story (e.g., a famous historical battle reenactment in our world or a holiday-themed adventure). Completing it gives unique rewards (maybe a special captain or cosmetic). - **Faction/Guild Events:** For instance, a server-wide event where players choose to align with a faction temporarily and compete through missions for that faction. At the end, all players of the winning faction get a reward (promotes social involvement and friendly rivalry). - **Live Story Events:** Using the narrative as a driver, we could have events that tease future story arcs. Example: a mysterious ghost ship appears on the map every day at a certain time – players can fight it and pieces of a puzzle story are revealed, leading into the next big update.

Monthly Live Ops Example: To illustrate, consider a typical month: - Week 1-2: **Summer Festival Event** – a themed event where players do special missions to collect “festival tokens” redeemable for a summer sail cosmetic and resources. Also a co-op boss (maybe a giant turtle creature) appears on weekends. - Week 3: New PvP Season start – ratings reset, new league rewards (introducing a new cosmetic flag as the top reward). A new captain is added to the recruitment pool. - Week 4: Minor content update adding two new ships (through tech tree or shop) and a couple of new campaign missions (if between major arcs, could be side story quests). Throughout, daily login rewards tie into these (e.g., during event, login gives some tokens).

Community and Communication: A successful live ops needs good communication. We'll maintain in-game news and possibly a community forum/Discord. Regular **developer messages** (like patch notes, upcoming features teasers) will be shared. We plan to run community contests (e.g. fan art of your ship, strategy video contests) to keep engagement outside the game too.

Monetization through Live Ops: Events often come with special store offers. For example, during a raid event, sell a “Raider Pack” that gives some extra raid attempts or damage boosts (not pay to win, but slight convenience like extra potions to heal ships faster between raid attempts). During a new captain release, offer a bundle “guarantee unlock Captain X” at a premium price for collectors who can't wait. A battle pass will align with the monthly content so its missions push players to engage in the new event modes.

Retention Mechanics: - **Daily Missions & Rewards:** Standard stuff – a list of daily tasks (win 2 battles, upgrade a ship, etc.) to keep players logging in. Completion yields useful stuff and progress on the battle pass. - **Streak or VIP rewards:** Perhaps a 7-day login streak yields a small premium reward or a random

shard. Or a monthly calendar of rewards. - **Guild engagement:** If players are in guilds, we'll ensure there are guild quests or guild currencies that encourage daily contributions (like check in and do one guild mission). Social bonds greatly improve retention.

Analytics-Driven Adjustments: Live Ops will watch key metrics – if a particular event shows low participation, we gather feedback and adjust difficulty or rewards accordingly next time. If we see players churning at a certain campaign mission (too hard), we patch it quickly. We also consider **dynamic difficulty or catch-up events:** e.g. for newer players, run periodic “Fast Track” events that help them level up ships quicker so they can join endgame content.

Monthly Content Delivery is also planned around **themes** to keep things coherent and marketable. For instance, announce “Pirate Month” – all events and releases revolve around pirates (introduce famous pirate captains, a pirate haven mini-story, discounts on pirate cosmetics). Then “Empire Month” focusing on navy, etc. This thematic approach gives players something to look forward to and is useful for our marketing beats.

Stability and Support: A live game needs robust customer support and technical stability. We'll have monitoring for server status during events (peak times might be when raids launch). If issues arise (like a bug in an event), we communicate transparently and compensate players appropriately – this maintains trust. We'll schedule maintenance windows for updates at off-peak times, and possibly use rolling updates to avoid downtime (if tech allows).

Expansion and Lifecycle: Assuming success, Armada could eventually expand beyond mobile (perhaps a PC version). But in any case, the Live Ops strategy will keep feeding new content. We'll evaluate after a year what major features players want (maybe they clamor for real-time PvP or larger 5v5 battles). We keep an eye on competitors and player sentiment to evolve the game. Our strategy gamers audience values depth, so one direction might be to add more simulation elements or user-generated content (like custom battles or a map editor to share scenarios, if feasible) as a long-term idea.

In summary, **Live Ops** for Armada is about making the game world feel alive and ever-evolving. By delivering regular events and updates, responding to player feedback, and fostering a strong community, we aim to extend the game's lifespan for many years. The monthly cadence ⁹ of new content and the engagement loops of daily/weekly activities ensure there's always a reason for players to set sail again and see what's new on the horizon.

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